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Liberal Authoritarianism

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In this article, SCSS President Stephen M. Krason examines the increasingly authoritarian trend present in American liberalism, particularly with regard to the matter of free speech. Once firm supporters of the ideal, today's liberals are increasingly against it. The author provides a number of examples of this trend, citing suppression via government overreach and officially-issued mandates, the stifling of alternative news media outlets, and the worrisome pattern of censorship on university campuses across the country. This ongoing program of suppression constitutes a form of tyranny, and makes hypocrites of those engaging in it. There are also signs that there may be a backlash building against this trend, but it will take some effort on the part of the defenders of free speech to make it happen. A different version of this article appeared in The Wanderer *on June 29, 2023.*

For some years now, things have been written about the increasingly authoritarian attitudes and practice of American liberalism. One of the leading books written on this subject, *The Closing of the Liberal Mind* by Kim R. Holmes (a historian and former U.S. Assistant Secretary of State) notes that, "Liberalism of all kinds, including the more progressive variety adopted by the ACLU in the 20th century, always made freedom of expression and speech a constitutionally protected principle. Not anymore. Today free speech is in progressive liberal circles clearly subordinated to other concerns."[1] He says that even while tending to reject a belief in absolute truth, liberals—the left generally—winds up treating what he calls "each local interpretation of truth" (i.e., particular liberal positions) as "effectively an absolute in and of itself."[2] As James Kalb writes in *The Tyranny of Liberalism*, "Liberal authorities insist that basic liberal understandings be put beyond question." He underscores how they see other perspectives as an outright threat: "They view nonliberal and therefore nonconsenting views . . . as a public danger that naturally leads to violence."[3]

We see many examples of the authoritarian bent of liberalism. There was the IRS's targeting of conservative organizations seeking tax-exempt status a decade ago. The top IRS official involved, Lois Lerner, also shared confidential taxpayer information with the Department of Justice to try to get it to open unmerited criminal investigations into some of the conservative organizations. The IRS even leaked one organization's donor list with the obvious objective of motivating people to harass and embarrass the

donors.[4] In case there was any question about political thinking motivating the IRS, Holmes brings out the fact that two-thirds of political donations by IRS employees over the nearly quarter-century before this episode went to Democrats.[5] Many more federal government bureaucrats are Democrats than Republicans, and thus tilt to the left.[6] Other examples include leftist state and local government officials targeting Christian clergy and church employees for dissenting from hard-core liberal positions. In Idaho in 2014, city officials told Protestant ministers that if they did not perform same-sex "weddings" they would face jail time. In Houston, Texas a lesbian mayor subpoenaed pastors' sermons and public statements to see if they opposed homosexuality. In 2019, the U.S. Supreme Court reversed Oregon's hefty financial penalty imposed on a baker for refusing to bake a "wedding" cake for a same-sex couple. Oakland, California threatened to fire any of their employees who set up a Christian employees association, even though they recognized a homosexual employees organization.[7] The liberal-dominated Ninth U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals,[8] centered in California, held that governments could censor terms such as "natural family" and "family values" as hate speech.[9] We have also observed the left effectively trying the force people to accept their moral perspective, even to provide funding to promote it. This was seen clearly with the contraception mandate in Obamacare. Recently, the Democratic Attorney General of the State of Washington, Robert Ferguson, has been pushing legislation that would criminally punish what he considers "misinformation"—which could be merely advocacy of politically conservative positions—on the grounds that it is "domestic violent extremism." The legislation would also compel counseling for people whose views fit into this category as determined by a commission it would set up to get them to change those views.[10] This sounds, to this writer, like essentially a form of "brainwashing." The left is not even reluctant to try to squash conservative-oriented media. Upon the urging of two Democratic members of the U.S. House of Representatives, AT&T's DirectTV took off two conservative-leaning news networks. One of these was Newsmax, which gets millions of viewers. Almost all other news networks are liberal-oriented.[11]

Currently, we are witnessing one of the most outrageous examples of liberal authoritarianism. The Democratic district attorney of Manhattan, New York City, has indicted former President Donald Trump for an alleged criminal violation of federal campaign laws—even though a state prosecutorial official has no role in enforcing those—and some other ill-defined "crimes" on the basis of claims made by Trump's former lawyer, who is notorious for lying and is a convicted felon. He has stretched and twisted the law to try to get the indictment, even though the U.S. Jus-

tice Department previously said the matter did not involve a violation of federal law. This, of course, follows from two baseless impeachments of Trump by the Democratic-controlled House of Representatives when he was in office, followed by claims that he purloined classified documents when he left office. All of this makes it appear that the rule of law, a central principle for a democratic republic, can be readily dispensed with by today's liberals for the sake of their political advantage.

Most American campuses have been known for their leftist orientation for a long time, but in recent years their intolerance of opposing viewpoints seems to have intensified. The Foundation for Individual Rights and Expression (FIRE), which especially monitors free speech in higher education, concluded from the annual survey that it does that in 2022 only about 12 percent of American universities and colleges had acceptable free speech policies. It says that many institutions also regulate campus events on the grounds of content and viewpoint.[12] We have seen such prominent conservative figures as Condoleezza Rice, Suzanne Venker, and Alan West disinvited or intimidated when they came to speak at universities[13] Even a federal appellate judge viewed as a conservative who was invited to speak at Stanford University Law School was shouted down by students who will be future members of the legal profession. That certainly does not auger well for sustaining the rule of law. The intolerance on campuses seems to have been bred in part at least by the eagerness to suppress non-leftist speech—as the Stanford episode illustrates—by students themselves. Catherine Rampell of *The Washington Post* has written how today's college students are both more leftist and more "openly hostile" to free speech than those in the past. They come to college already having those views (possibly shaped by their leftist-oriented pre-college public school education). They particularly want to suppress "racist" and "sexist" speech on campus, without defining what these terms mean—in other words, inviting a sweeping suppression of speech.[14] They also are insisting on more "diversity" and "diversity sensitivity training." These are obviously more examples of leftist "brainwashing," trying aggressively to reshape people's thinking along the lines of leftist ideology.[15] As far as pre-college education—specifically, public education—is concerned, we witness the same suppression of non-leftist thinking as in higher education. In at least three states, public school teachers have been suspended or forced to resign because they refused, on the basis of their Christian beliefs, to use students' preferred pronouns or names when they claimed to be the gender they were not.[16] More outrageous is the fact that a large number of public school districts around the country have policies in place that require withholding from parents the claims of their enrolled children to be a different sex than they actually are.[17] Presi-

dent Biden has been pushing to expand federal anti-discrimination law to include protection for gender identity, which is likely to have the effect of making it a *federal mandate* that schools keep parents from learning about their children's claimed gender identity.[18] Transgenderism, of course, has become a leading element of the liberal agenda. Then, there is the matter of the Tech "oligarchs"—known for their leftist bent—who suppress views that go against liberal orthodoxy. So, we see conservative views substantially pushed off Facebook, Pinterest, YouTube, Twitter (now X), etc.[19]

Kalb explains how liberalism developed this intolerant, repressive, even (he says) totalitarian-oriented mindset—even if it is a milder type of tyranny than we see in true totalitarian regimes. He says it is "a self-contained and all-embracing scheme for life in society" and that "ruling elites" who are predominantly liberal freely "reinterpret that scheme and change its practical meaning" and can overcome "the barriers to political action at odds with that scheme." Further, the "centralization of social life and pervasive regulation make all significant social institutions agents of the state," and these are controlled throughout the Western world by those with a liberal mindset. The governing "liberal elite" and institutions "reject custom as a standard"—which was something that restrained kingly pretentions to absolutism in earlier centuries—and their ability to force their ideology on society "is not limited by any substantive external point of reference." In other words, something like natural law is not a restraining force because they do not believe in it and it is not widely stressed in modern society as a real force restraining men's actions. Liberals say that freedom and equality should govern, but these are "content-free and can be made to mean anything when taken as ultimate standards." So, liberal relativism runs amuck. Further, Kalb says, its power is pervasive: "The advanced liberal state is able to do a thing almost invisibly because of the very scope of its power."[20] Indeed, as Holmes tells us, the pushing aside of good arguments, the unwillingness to even engage in discussion with or give any credence to those with opposing views, the intellectual dishonesty that now so typically characterizes liberalism, and the belief that its ideology cannot be challenged—as Joel Kotkin says it makes "the authoritarian demand for unanimity on virtually all issues"—creates "a political and intellectual culture of mediocrity and dishonesty" and in the end brings everything down to just getting and keeping political power.[21] One hardly needs to say that the implications of that for civil peace and even maintaining the character of a democratic republic are troubling. Indeed, the upshot of such a perspective is outright collectivist.

Matthew Hutson writes that research shows that while there is not much regard that people on both sides of the political spectrum have for each other's opinions, liberals are particularly hypocritical because they

"might like to think of themselves as more open-mined" but they really are not.[22] That is abundantly illustrated by what was said above. One wonders if the only element liberals are truly tolerant of is the far left. Indeed, they have increasingly embraced the views of the far left.[23] While liberals like to think of themselves as upholding a democratic worldview, columnist Jonah Goldberg tells us that their intolerant thinking is driven by liberal elites—the liberal opinion-makers.[24] The increasingly anti-democratic thinking of liberals comes from the top down.

Is there any way to reverse the effects of liberal-generated intolerance and oppression? Holmes suggests that liberals may be overconfident in thinking that they can successfully suppress opposing thinking and remake American politics and life according to their ideology. He says that "Americans do not like bullies"[25] and that "backlash" against what he calls "progressive illiberalism may be building." A "diverse coalition could emerge to challenge . . . the postmodern left," made up of moderate liberals (he believes there still are some), libertarians, social conservatives, and religious people.[26] People, however, have to come forth, make the effort, show basic courage, and be willing to assert themselves irrespective of the opposition and criticism they will receive for this to happen.

Notes

1. Kim R. Holmes, *The Closing of the Liberal Mind: How Groupthink and Intolerance Define the Left* (New York: Encounter Books, 2017), 156.
2. Ibid., 48.
3. James Kalb, *The Tyranny of Liberalism: Understanding and Overcoming Administered Freedom, Inquisitorial Tolerance, and Equality by Command* (Wilmington, Del.: ISI Books, 2008).
4. Holmes, *The Closing of the Liberal Mind*, 125–26.
5. Ibid., 127.
6. "Civil Servants Often Work for Administrations They Disagree with Politically: How Does This Affect Their Job Performance?" *Kellogg Insight* (June 1, 2021), https://insight.kellogg.northwestern.edu/article/civil-servants-political-ideology, accessed 2 March, 2023.
7. Holmes, *The Closing of the Liberal Mind*, 129–30.
8. See Craig Anderson, "Biden Names 3 California Judges to Fill 9th Circuit Vacancies, 2 to District Court in Los Angeles," *Daily Journal* (Sept. 7, 2021), https://www.dailyjournal.com/articles/364133-biden-to-name-three-california-judges-to-9th-circuit-vacancies.
9. Holmes, *The Closing of the Liberal Mind*, 130.
10. Michele Blood, "AG Pushes State Level 'Ministry of Truth' Critics Say Could Jail Conservatives Who Express Mainstream Views," *Blaze Media/News*, March 5, 2023.

11. Tim Meads, "What's with AT&T's DirectTV Kicking Out Conservative Newsmax and OAN?" *DailyWire.com*, Jan. 27, 2023.

12. Quin Hillyer, "Communication Commissars Continue Contaminating College Campuses," *Washington Examiner*, Dec.13, 2022, https://www.washingtonexaminer.com/opinion/communication-commissars-continue-contaminating-college-campuses.

13. See: Catherine Rampell, "Liberal Intolerance Is on the Rise on America's College Campuses," *Milwaukee Journal Sentinel*, Feb., 14, 2016, https://archive.jsonline.com/news/opinion/liberal-intolerance-is-on-the-rise-on-americas-college-campuses-b9966 9487 z1-368692121.html/; "Alan West Escorted from YAF Event by Policy, Irate Mob Chases and Assaults Conservative Student," *New Guard*, April 7, 2022, https://www.yaf.org/news/breaking-allen-west-escorted-from-yaf-event-by-police-irate-mob-chases-and-assaults-conservative-student/.

14. Rampell. As an interesting sidenote, which perhaps helps to explain the growing willingness among college students to see free speech suppressed, is that fewer than one-third of millennials think it's important to give in a democracy (i.e., a democratic republic) (Joel Kotkin, "The Rise of the Intolerant Left," *New Geography*, June 25, 2019).

15. Catherine Rampell, "Liberal Intolerance Is on the Rise on America's College Campuses," slightly altered article from the above on Feb. 15, 2016, https://archive.jsonline.com/news/opinion/liberal-intolerance-is-on-the-rise-on-americas-college-campuses-b9966 9487 z1-368692121.html/.

16. Mairead Elordi, "Ohio Teacher Forced Out for Refusing to Affirm Students' New Gender Identity, Lawsuit Claims," *The Daily Wire* (Dec. 19, 2022), https://www.dailywire.com/news/ohio-teacher-forced-out-for-refusing-to-affirm-students-new-gender-identity-lawsuit-claims.

17. Josh Christenson, "Nearly 6,000 Public Schools Hide Child's Gender Status from Parents," *New York Post* (March 19, 2023), https://nypost.com/2023/03/08/us-public-schools-conceal-childs-gender-status-from-parents/.

18. Kaylee McGhee White, "Biden's New Title IX Rules Deputize Teachers to Override Parents on Gender Identity," *New York Post* (April 15, 2022), https://nypost.com/2022/08/15/bidens-title-ix-rules-deputize-teachers-to-override-parents/.

19. Kotkin, "The Rise of the Intolerant Left."

20. Kalb, *The Tyranny of Liberalism*, 129.

21. Holmes, *The Closing of the Liberal Mind*, 261. The quote from Kotkin is from his article above.

22. Matthew Hutson, "Why Liberals Aren't as Tolerant as They Think," Politico (May 9, 2017), https://www.politico.com/magazine/story/2017/05/09/why-liberals-arent-as-tolerant-as-they-think-215114/.

23. Holmes, *The Closing of the Liberal Mind*, 246.

24. Ibid., 265–66.

25. Ibid., 264.

26. Ibid., 265–66.